

Properties of elements



Alkali metals

These are soft, lightweight metals that react easily with other chemicals, such as water. When put in water, they fizz and pop violently. Sodium is an alkali metal. It reacts with the gas chlorine to form common salt.

Transition metals

This group includes well-known and useful metals.



Silver is used in medals, ornaments, jewelry, and flatware (knives and forks).



Zinc protects things from rusting. One of its many uses is in the casing of batteries.



Nickel is used in silver-colored coins because it does not lose its shine.



Titanium is lightweight yet incredibly strong. It is used to repair bones and joints.

In the periodic table, elements with similar properties are arranged in groups. Some groups are made up of elements that react easily with other chemicals to form new compounds. Other groups include elements that barely react with anything at all.

What are transition metals?

Forty elements make up a group known as the transition metals. These are typical metals, being solid, shiny, and mostly hard. The precious metals gold, silver, and platinum are in this group.

Pure gold is found as grains in rock or, more rarely, as whole rocks (nuggets) that are worth a small fortune.



Precious metals such as gold are long-lasting because they react poorly with other chemicals. Gold is one of the least reactive elements.

